always been to keep enemies out and not subjects in. This wall is a repulsive thing. It is repulsive to read about and even more repulsive to see in reality.’6

Amid the furore, the most balanced early assessment was given by Lord Montgomery, the British hero of the Second World War and former commander of British Forces in Germany. ‘To describe Germany as one Germany is just a pious fraud. You cannot have one Germany.’ Asked if the situation alarmed him, he took a slightly more hectoring tone:

I do not think the East has any intention of attacking the West and I do not think the West has any intention of attacking the East. I think the whole thing has blown up because of the mistrust and suspicion between the two sides. The East thinks the West is going to attack. The West thinks the East is going to attack. Neither side has any intention of attacking the other.7

He was right, and as the dust settled, little happened other than Willy Brandt warning against ‘dangerous resistance’ and the Western Allies reinforcing their garrisons with a few tanks. ‘It turns out nobody was upset by it,’ Honecker contended in 1990. ‘Some went fishing [a reference to JFK who when informed, remarked: ‘A wall is a hell of a lot better than a war’]. It brought some relief, so to speak, when this action was taken.’ He continued: ‘Washington, London, Paris, Moscow and us, we all thought it would de-escalate the situation. We all assumed it would ensure peace.’8 In his German-language memoirs, he gave a thoroughly romantic justification by asking how could the GDR ‘stand by and watch as our republic was bled dry in an economic war like no other?’

We took no different action than any other independent, sovereign state. We merely took our defensible frontiers under control in accordance with the international law enshrined then, as now, by the United Nations. This saved